MICHIGAN STATE UNIVERSITY

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EDUCATION

Ph.D., Communication, Michigan State University, United States, Expected May 2027
Dissertation: *AI as Relational Mediator: Language, Self-Presentation, and Impression Formation*
Co-chairs: Dr. David M. Markowitz and Dr. Brandon Van Der Heide
Committee: Dr. Yoo Jung (Erika) Oh and Dr. David Ewoldsen

M.Sc., with *Distinction*, AI and Digital Media, Hong Kong Baptist University, HKSAR, 2020
Specializations: Computational communication research and digital journalism
Advisor: Dr. Xinzhi Zhang
Valedictorian (Class of 2020)

B.A., Ethnology, Southwest University, China, 2018

RESEARCH INTERESTS

Technology-mediated communication: Computer-mediated communication, AI-mediated collaboration, human-AI collaboration, online self-presentation, online impression formation
Language and communication: Psychology of language
Computational communication research: Natural language processing and social network analysis

PEER-REVIEWED PUBLICATIONS

10. **Zhu, R.**, Markowitz, D. M., & Van Der Heide, B. (in press). Revisiting warranting theory in AI-mediated communication: An evaluation of writer and source effects in hotel reviews. *Technology, Mind, and Behavior.*

9. **Zhu, R.**, Markowitz, D. M., & Van Der Heide, B. (2026). Presenting the augmented self: Extending sender effects of the hyperpersonal model in artificial intelligence-mediated communication. *Annals of the International Communication Association,* wlag029. https://doi.org/10.1093/anncom/wlag029

8. Oh, Y. J., Hu, J. M., **Zhu, R.**, Lim, J. I., & Zhang, X. (2026). Exerting social influence by building human-AI chatbot relationships: A systematic review. *International Journal of Human-Computer Interaction*, *0*(0), 1–25. https://doi.org/10.1080/10447318.2026.2648799

7. Pham, D. T., Van Der Heide, B., **Zhu, R.**, & Rathjens, B. (2026). The effects of metacognition on the sender's feedback effect in computer-mediated communication. *Communication Studies*, *77*(4), 552–568. https://doi.org/10.1080/10510974.2025.2486608

6. McKinley, E., Markowitz, D. M., **Zhu, R.**, & Van Der Heide, B. (2025). Evaluating AI use and its psychological correlates via months of web-browsing data. *Cyberpsychology, Behavior, and Social Networking*, *28*(10), 680–688. https://doi.org/10.1177/21522715251379987

5. Hu, J. M., **Zhu, R.**, & Zhang, Y. (2024). Does online dating make relationships more successful? Replication and extension of a previous study. *Cyberpsychology, Behavior, and Social Networking,* 27(9), 635–640. https://doi.org/10.1089/cyber.2024.0136

4. Zhang, X., & **Zhu, R.** (2024). Health journalists' social media sourcing during the early outbreak of the public health emergency. *Journalism Practice*, 18(7), 1660–1680. https://doi.org/10.1080/17512786.2022.2110927

3. Zhang, X., **Zhu, R.**, Chen, L., Zhang, Z., & Chen, M. (2024). News from Messenger? A cross-national comparative study of news media's audience engagement strategies via Facebook Messenger chatbots. *Digital Journalism*, 12(3), 336–355. https://doi.org/10.1080/21670811.2022.2145329

2. **Zhu, R.**, & Zhang, X. (2023). Public sector's misinformation debunking during the public health campaign: A case of Hong Kong. *Health Promotion International*, *38*(3), daad053. https://doi.org/10.1093/heapro/daad053

1. Zhang, X., & **Zhu, R.** (2022). How source-level and message-level factors influence journalists' social media visibility during a public health crisis. *Journalism*, 23(12), 2627–2645. https://doi.org/10.1177/14648849211023153

Under Review or Revise & Resubmit

Zhu, R., Huang, L., & Hu, J. M. (revise & resubmit). Stigma, support, and LGB mental health: A longitudinal analysis.

Zhu, R., Hu, J. M., & Oh, Y. J. (revise & resubmit). Who uses AI for relational matters? Roles of social anxiety and mind perception.

Zhu, R., Oh, Y. J., Zhang, X., Forsyth, S., Markowitz, D. M., & Van Der Heide, B. (revise & resubmit). Accommodating to the machine? Linguistic style accommodation in human-AI chatbot conversations.

Zhu, R., Forsyth, S., Van Der Heide, B., & Markowitz, D. M. (under review). Can AI Make You More Attractive? The Impact of AI Enhancement on Linguistic Cues and Impression Formation in Online Dating Profiles.

Hu, J. M., **Zhu, R.**, & Oh, Y. J. (under review). Problematic attachment to AI chatbots: Testing the Revised Social Anxiety Model.

Selected Manuscript In Preparation

Zhu, R., Markowitz, D. M., Van Der Heide, B., Forsyth, S., & Zhang, X. (in preparation). More than hyperpersonal: Comparing language, interaction dynamics, and relational communication in AI-mediated and computer-mediated communication.

Zhu, R., Pham, D. T., & Van Der Heide, B. (in preparation). Write with AI, persuade the self: An examination of attitude change through co-writing with AI.

Liu, H., **Zhu, R.,** & Markowitz, D. M. (in preparation). Chatting with AI to reduce social anxiety: An experience sampling methods research.

INVITED BOOK CHAPTERS

2. Van Der Heide, B., Markowitz, D. M., **Zhu, R.**, & Forsyth, S. M. (in press). Impression management in computer-mediated communication. In E. Sumner, A. Ramirez, J. Hall & B. McEwan (Eds.), *The Handbook of Relational and Computer-Mediated Communication*. Routledge/Taylor and Francis

1. Markowitz, D. M., **Zhu, R.**, & Van Der Heide, B. (in press). Machines as communicative opposites. In M. Heim & E. Domahidi (Eds.), *The handbook of computational communication research*. Routledge/Taylor and Francis

CONFERENCE PRESENTATIONS

20. **Zhu, R.**, Forsyth, S., Zhang, X., Van Der Heide, B., & Markowitz, D. M. (2026, November). *Extended Abstract: When AI enhances your online dating profile: The effects on language and impression formation.* Extended Abstract presented at the National Communication Association's (NCA) 112th Annual Conference. New Orleans, LA.

19. **Zhu, R.**, Markowitz, D. M., & Van Der Heide, B. (2026, November). *Presenting the augmented self: Extending sender effects of the hyperpersonal model to AI-mediated communication.* Paper presented at the National Communication Association's (NCA) 112th Annual Conference. New Orleans, LA.

18. **Zhu, R.**, Hu, J. M., & Oh, Y. J. (2026, November). *Social anxiety, mind perception, and using AI for relationship help.* Paper presented at the National Communication Association's (NCA) 112th Annual Conference. New Orleans, LA.

17. **Zhu, R.**, Oh, Y. J., Zhang, X., Forsyth, S. M., Markowitz, D. M., & Van Der Heide, B. (2026, June). *How we accommodate to AI: Linguistic style accommodation and its effects*

in human-AI chatbot conversations. Paper presented at the 76th Annual Conference of the International Communication Association (ICA). Cape Town, South Africa.

16. **Zhu, R.** (2026, June). *When AI generates emotion support message: Gender attribution and the effectiveness of emotional support in AI-mediated communication.* Poster presented at the 76th Annual Conference of the International Communication Association (ICA). Cape Town, South Africa.

15. **Zhu, R.**, Markowitz, D. M., & Van Der Heide, B. (2025, November). *Revisiting warranting theory in AI-mediated communication: An evaluation of writer and source effects in hotel reviews.* Paper presented at the National Communication Association's (NCA) 111th Annual Conference. Denver, CO.

14. **Zhu, R.**, Huang, L., & Hu, J. M. (2025, November). *Stigma, support, and LGB mental health: A longitudinal analysis*. Paper presented at the National Communication Association's (NCA) 111th Annual Conference. Denver, CO.

13. Yang, J., Baldwin, J., Grady, S., **Zhu, R.**, Lim, J. I., Markowitz, D. M., & Zhang, J. (2025, June). *An agenda for generative artificial intelligence in content analysis: Navigating opportunities, challenges, and considerations in AI-aided content analysis*. Paper presented at the 75th Annual Conference of the International Communication Association (ICA), Denver.

12. Oh, Y. J., Hu, J. M., **Zhu, R.**, & Lim, J. I. (2024, November). *Exerting social influence by building human-AI chatbot relationships: A systematic review*. Paper presented at the National Communication Association's (NCA) 110th Annual Conference. New Orleans, LA.

11. Pham, D., Van Der Heide, B., Rathjens, B., **Zhu, R.**, & Bredland, A. (2024, November). *The effects of metacognition on senders' feedback effect in CMC.* Paper presented at the National Communication Association's (NCA) 110th Annual Conference. New Orleans, LA.

10. **Zhu, R.** (2024, June). *The spiral of silence on social media: Systematically reviewing methodological approaches.* Paper presented at the 74th Annual Conference of the International Communication Association (ICA), Gold Coast, Australia.

9. Pham, D., Van Der Heide, B., Rathjens, B., **Zhu, R.**, & Bredland, A. (2024, June). *Metacognition's impact on senders' feedback effect in CMC*. Paper presented at the 74th Annual Conference of the International Communication Association (ICA), Gold Coast, Australia.

8. Rathjens, B., Van Der Heide, B., **Zhu, R.**, & Pham, D. (2024, April). *Motivations unveiled: How altruism and self-interest shape exaggeration behavior*. Paper presented at Central States Communication Association (CSCA) Annual Convention. Grand Rapids, MI.

7. Rathjens, B., Van Der Heide, B., Pham, D., **Zhu, R.**, & Bredland, A. (2024, March). *Deceptive online review writing: Unraveling the role of self-interest, ethical norms, and moral disengagement*. Paper presented at the 2024 Association for Business Communication (ABC) Southwestern U.S. Conference. Galveston, TX.

6. **Zhu, R.** (2023, June). *More social media platforms used, more political participation? The roles of discussion heterogeneity preference and ideological extremity.* Paper presented at the online component of the International Association for Media and Communication Research (IAMCR) 2023.

5. **Zhu, R.**, & Zhang, X. (2023, May). *Public sector's misinformation debunking during the public health campaign: A case of Hong Kong.* Poster presented at the 73rd Annual Conference of the International Communication Association (ICA), Toronto, Canada. ***- Top Poster Award (Health Communication Division)***

4. Zhang, X., & **Zhu, R.** (2023, May). *Will political disagreement silence political expression? The roles of information repertoire filtration and discussion network heterogeneity.* Paper presented at the 73rd Annual Conference of the International Communication Association (ICA), Toronto, Canada.

3. Fu, X., Zhang, X., **Zhu, R.**, Ping, H., & Chang, Y. (2022, May). *"FALSE! Read about it here!" Fact-checkers' social media language feature and its effects on user engagement.* Paper presented at the 72nd Annual Conference of the International Communication Association (ICA), Paris, France.

2. **Zhu, R.**, & Zhang, X. (2021, May). *How source-level and message-level factors influence journalists' social media visibility during a public health emergency.* Paper presented at the 71st Annual Conference (virtual) of the International Communication Association (ICA).

1. Zhang, X., & **Zhu, R.** (2021, May). *Health journalists' social media sourcing during the public health emergency: A network analytics approach.* Paper presented at the 71st Annual Conference (virtual) of the International Communication Association (ICA).

AWARDS AND RECOGNITIONS

Fellowship and Scholarship

2025 Kumata Fellowship, Michigan State University, $2,500
2025 Open Science Scholarship Fellowship, Michigan State University, $200
2025 Graduate Office Fellowship, Michigan State University, $2,000
2024 Graduate Office Fellowship, Michigan State University, $2,000
2023 Graduate Office Fellowship, Michigan State University, $2,000
2022-2023 University Grant (UG) Studentship of Hong Kong Baptist University, HKSAR
2020 The 1st Class (Merit-Based) Scholarship, Hong Kong Baptist University, HKSAR

2016 The 2nd Class (Merit-Based) Scholarship, Southwest University, China

Award

2026 Graduate Office Fellowship Travel Award, Communication Arts & Sciences Dean's Office, Michigan State University, $3,500
2023 Top Poster Award: International Communication Association, Health Communication Division
2023 Graduate Office Fellowship Travel Award, Communication Arts & Sciences Dean's Office, Michigan State University, $1,667
2023 Best Teaching Assistant Award for the ITS1008 Global Challenges, Division of Transdisciplinary Undergraduate Programmes, Hong Kong Baptist University, HKSAR
2020 Best Arts and Innovation Award, The Global Virtual Hack and Design Challenge – Empower Community during and after COVID-19, organized by Hong Kong Baptist University, HKSAR

Honor

2020 Class Valedictorian for 2020 Commencement, Hong Kong Baptist University, HKSAR
2020 Scholastic Award for the Class of 2020, Hong Kong Baptist University, HKSAR
2015 Outstanding Individual in Volunteer Activities, Southwest University, China

GRANT AND RESEARCH FUND

2026 Dissertation Completion Fellowship, College of Communication, Arts & Sciences, Michigan State University, $5,333
Role: Sole recipient
Supporting completion of dissertation research on AI-mediated communication

2026 Seed Grant, Department of Communication, Michigan State University, $3,000
Role: Co-Investigator, with Dr. David M. Markowitz and Dr. David Ewoldsen (PIs) and Hanjie Liu
A longitudinal experience sampling methods (ESM) study examining the effects of AI chatbot use on social anxiety

CONTRIBUTIONS TO EXTERNALLY FUNDED RESEARCH

Research Assistant, School of Communication, Hong Kong Baptist University, HKSAR, Aug 2020 – May 2022
Project title: *Engaging the Audience with AI-powered News Chatbots: Developing and Evaluating a Critiquing-oriented Conversational Recommender System for Digital News*.
Details: A project funded by the Interdisciplinary Research Clusters Matching Scheme (IRCMS) by the University Research Clusters, Hong Kong Baptist University. PI: Dr. Li Chen (Associate Professor and Program Director, Department of Computer Science, Hong Kong Baptist University)
Responsibilities: Designed a codebook for annotating interactions between humans and news chatbots, and wrote research papers

Project title: *Sci-fi Blockbusters' Representation of Female Cyborgs and Its Impacts on Audiences' Perception of Human-Machine Communication*.

Details: A project funded by the Digital Scholarship Grant (DSG), Hong Kong Baptist University Library. PI: Dr. Xinzhi Zhang (Associate Professor, City University of Hong Kong)

Responsibilities: Prepared and moderated focus group discussions about how movie viewers perceived AI, robots, and virtual agents portrayed in Sci-fi movies

Outcome: https://digital.lib.hkbu.edu.hk/cyborg/index.php

Project title: *Why Fact-Checking Fails? Factors Influencing the Effectiveness of Corrective Messages Countering Misinformation on Social Media: A Comparison of Hong Kong, the United States, and the Netherlands*.

Details: A project funded by the General Research Fund (GRF), the Research Grants Council (RGC), Hong Kong SAR. PI: Dr. Xinzhi Zhang (Associate Professor, City University of Hong Kong)

Responsibilities: Assisted the principal investigator in preparing trilingual survey questionnaires, harvested tweets of fact-check centers in Hong Kong, the United States, and the Netherlands via Twitter API, preprocessed the data, collected Hong Kong public sector's COVID-19 vaccine-related debunking messages published on different online channels, and performed content analysis

Project title: *The Making and Unmaking of the Public Sphere: Outcomes of Political Disagreement, Expression Avoidance, and a Filtered Information Repertoire*.

Details: A project funded by the General Research Fund (GRF), the Research Grants Council (RGC), Hong Kong SAR. PI: Dr. Xinzhi Zhang (Associate Professor, City University of Hong Kong)

Responsibilities: Designed the codebook for annotating news articles, performed manual coding, and prepared and moderated online focus group discussions about political disagreement-motivated unfriending

TEACHING EXPERIENCE

Instructor of Record

COM 225 An Introduction to Interpersonal Communication (Undergraduate), Department of Communication, Michigan State University (2026 Summer)

Class size: 38 students

Responsibilities: Developed syllabus, asynchronously lectured on interpersonal communication, monitored student progress, and evaluated assignments for grading

COM 100 Human Communication (Undergraduate), Department of Communication, Michigan State University (2025 Summer)

Class size: 28 students

Responsibilities: Asynchronously lectured on public speaking, monitored student progress, and evaluated student assignments for grading

Course Coordinator
COM 100 Human Communication (Undergraduate), Department of Communication, Michigan State University (2025 Fall & 2026 Spring)
Responsibilities: Participated in course preparation and syllabus development, overseeing approximately 400 students across 8 TA sections, facilitated communication between the course instructor (Dr. Dustin Carnahan) and the 8 TAs, advised and supported TAs on teaching practices, and oversaw their instructional responsibilities

Teaching Assistant
COM 225 An Introduction to Interpersonal Communication (Undergraduate), Department of Communication, Michigan State University (2026 Fall)
Class size: 498 students
Responsibilities: Lectured on specific topics in interpersonal communication, monitored student progress, and evaluated assignments

COM 100 Human Communication (Undergraduate), Department of Communication, Michigan State University (2023 Fall, 2024 Spring, & 2026 Spring)
Class size: around 60 students each semester
Responsibilities: Led 3 recitation sections, provided instruction in public speaking, led speech practice exercises, and evaluated student assignments

COM 300 Methods of Communication Inquiry (Undergraduate), Department of Communication, Michigan State University (2024 Fall & 2025 Spring)
Class size: around 50 students each semester
Responsibilities: Led 2 recitation sections, expanded on concepts introduced in lecture, facilitated in-class hands-on statistical analysis, and evaluated student assignments

ITS1008 Global Challenges (Undergraduate), Division of Transdisciplinary Undergraduate Programmes (DTUP), Hong Kong Baptist University, HKSAR (2022 Fall)
Class size: 95
Responsibilities: Supported student learning, led field visits, and mentored 6 groups on their final projects
Awarded "Best Teaching Assistant Award"

AIDM7340 AI for Digital Media (Postgraduate), Hong Kong Baptist University, HKSAR (2021 Fall)
Class size: 89
Responsibilities: Supported student learning and evaluated assignments for grading

GUEST LECTURE

COM 225 An Introduction to Interpersonal Communication (Undergraduate), Department of Communication, Michigan State University (2026 Fall)
Topic: Friendship in the Age of Artificial Intelligence

Class size: around 500 students

COM 100 Human Communication (Undergraduate), Department of Communication, Michigan State University (2026 Spring)
Topic: Nonverbal communication
Class size: around 400 students

COM 300 Methods of Communication Inquiry (Undergraduate), Department of Communication, Michigan State University (2025 Spring)
Topic: Using computers in social science research
Class size: around 200 students

AIDM7410 Computational Journalism (Postgraduate), Hong Kong Baptist University, HKSAR (2019 - 2021 Fall)
Topic: Harvesting social media data and conducting automated content analysis using RStudio and Python
Class size: around 40 each term

MEDIA COVERAGE

Psychology Today, 2024: Social Media Chat Can Strengthen Romantic Relationships
The positive effects of social media on relationships
https://www.psychologytoday.com/ca/blog/love-digitally/202409/social-media-chat-can-strengthen-romantic-relationships

SERVICE

Ad hoc reviewer for journals
2026 International Journal of Human-Computer Interaction
2026 Family Relations
2026 Behaviour & Information Technology
2025-2026 Cyberpsychology, Behavior and Social Networking

Ad hoc reviewer for conferences
2025-2026 National Communication Association
2021-2026 International Communication Association

Volunteer for conferences and panels
2026 Paper session chair, National Communication Association Annual Convention
2026 Invited topical discussion chair, "Computer-Mediated Communication in the Age of AI," Communication Science Futures Conference, East Lansing, MI
2026 Volunteer to serve as the photographer for a panel hosted by ComArtSci Communication Solutions for a Diverse Society (CS4DS), East Lansing, MI
Nominated for ComArtSci/WKAR Employee Gratitude
2024 Volunteer for the 2024 Communication Science Futures Conference, East Lansing, MI

MICHIGAN STATE UNIVERSITY

Department
2026 President, Association of Graduate Students in Communication, MSU
2025 Vice President, Association of Graduate Students in Communication, MSU

PROFESSIONAL MEMBERSHIP

International Communication Association, member, 2021 to present
National Communication Association, member, 2024 to present

SKILLS

Workshop and training: ICPSR Applied Multilevel Models for Longitudinal and Clustered Data, Summer 2026
Analysis: Natural language processing, social network analysis, large language models-assisted content analysis, multilevel modeling, and cross-lagged panel modeling
Programming language: R and Python
Applications: LIWC, Gephi, Tableau, and SPSS
Language: English (professional), Mandarin (Native), and Cantonese (professional)

REFERENCES

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